Question ID: ac5536c1

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Beatrix Potter is perhaps best known for writing and illustrating children's books such as *The Tale of Peter Rabbit* (1902), but she also dedicated herself to mycology, the study of _____ more than 350 paintings of the fungal species she observed in nature and submitting her research on spore germination to the Linnean Society of London.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

A. fungi; producing

B. fungi. Producing

C. fungi producing

D. fungi, producing

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between two supplementary phrases following the coordinate clause ("but she…mycology"). This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the supplementary noun phrase ("the study of fungi") that defines the term "mycology" and the supplementary participial phrase ("producing...London") that provides additional information about the extent to which Potter dedicated herself to mycology.

Choice A is incorrect because a semicolon can't be used in this way to join two supplementary phrases following a coordinate clause. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with "producing." Choice C is incorrect. The lack of punctuation results in a sentence that illogically suggests that the study of fungi is producing more than 350 paintings.

Question ID: 1aa3f174

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

The Mesoamerican city of Teotihuacan featured a uniquely egalitarian urban housing infrastructure. Built between the first and seventh centuries CE, Teotihuacan housed its residents (as many as 200,000, by some _____ in a complex of comfortable apartments of comparable size.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

A. estimates)

B. estimates),

C. estimates—

D. estimates

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is the use of punctuation within a sentence. This choice correctly completes the parenthetical element "as many as 200,000, by some estimates" with a closing parenthesis, pairing with the opening parenthesis that appears earlier in the sentence. This parenthetical element functions to specify the number of residents, and the use of parentheses indicates that this element could be removed without affecting the grammatical coherence of the sentence.

Choice B is incorrect. While this choice completes the parenthetical element with a closing parenthesis, no comma is needed before the prepositional phrases ("in...size") that provide essential information about where the residents were housed. Choice C is incorrect because a dash can't be paired with an opening parenthesis in this way to separate the parenthetical element from the rest of the sentence. Choice D is incorrect because it doesn't close the parenthetical element that was opened earlier in the sentence.

Question ID: 145d5ca7

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Gathering accurate data on water flow in the United States is challenging because of the country's millions of miles of _____ the volume and speed of water at any given location can vary drastically over time.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

A. waterways and the fact that,

B. waterways, and the fact that,

C. waterways, and, the fact that

D. waterways and the fact that

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation within two coordinated noun phrases. When, as in this case, a noun phrase ("the country's millions of miles of waterways") is coordinated with another noun phrase ("the fact") followed by an integrated relative clause ("that the volume...time"), no punctuation is needed.

Choice A is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Choice B is incorrect because no punctuation is needed. Choice C is incorrect because no punctuation is needed.

Question ID: be34a3df

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

In 2008, two years after the death of science fiction writer Octavia Butler, the Huntington Library in _____ received a collection of more than 8,000 items, including Butler's private notes, research materials, manuscripts, photos, and drawings. Today, the Octavia E. Butler Collection is one of the most researched archives at the library.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

A. California,

B. California:

C. California—

D. California

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. No punctuation should separate the subject of the sentence ("the Huntington Library in California") from its verb ("received").

Choice A is incorrect. No punctuation should separate the subject of the sentence ("the Huntington Library in California") from its verb ("received"). Choice B is incorrect. No punctuation should separate the subject of the sentence ("the Huntington Library in California") from its verb ("received"). Choice C is incorrect. No punctuation should separate the subject of the sentence ("the Huntington Library in California") from its verb ("received").

Question ID: 8f6d6ae6

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Archaeologists have estimated that the pre-Columbian Native American city of Cahokia, located across the Mississippi River from modern-day St. Louis, Missouri, had as many as 20,000 inhabitants in the year 1150 _____ it one of the largest cities in North America at the time.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

A. CE making

B. CE. Making

C. CE, making

D. CE; making

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The phrase “making…at the time” provides additional information about Cahokia that’s not required for the sentence to make sense or function grammatically. As a nonessential supplement, this phrase should be separated from the rest of the sentence with a comma.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence. The nonessential descriptive aside “making…at the time” needs to be separated from the rest of the sentence with a comma. Choice B is incorrect. This choice results in a sentence fragment. “Making…at the time” doesn’t have a subject and can’t stand on its own as a sentence. Thus, it can’t be separated from the rest of the sentence with a period. Choice D is incorrect. This choice results in a punctuation error. “Making…at the time” doesn’t have a subject and can’t stand on its own as an independent clause. Since a semicolon can only link two independent clauses, using one here creates an error.

Question ID: 870ae7ec

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Detroit natives Timothy Paule and Nicole Lindsey have combined their two passions, Detroit and beekeeping, to improve the health of their city's flowers and other vegetation. In 2017, the couple converted a vacant lot in the city into an _____ in the years that followed they acquired nine additional lots and established more than 35 hives.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

A. apiary,

B. apiary, and

C. apiary and

D. apiary

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. Both clauses in this sentence could stand alone as complete sentences, which means they are both independent clauses. This choice uses a comma plus a coordinating conjunction to link them together, which is one of the correct ways to link two independent clauses.

Choice A is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence error. Both clauses in this sentence could stand alone as complete sentences, which means they are both independent clauses. A comma by itself is not enough punctuation to link two independent clauses. Choice C is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence error. Both clauses in this sentence could stand alone as complete sentences, which means they are both independent clauses. Independent clauses can only be linked in a few ways, including with a comma plus a coordinating conjunction. This choice uses the coordinating conjunction "and," but it is missing the comma beforehand. Choice D is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence error. Both clauses in this sentence could stand alone as complete sentences, which means they are both independent clauses. Independent clauses need to have certain kinds of punctuation marks between them. This choice doesn't use any punctuation between the two clauses.

Question ID: b0a525be

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Santa Clara Pueblo artist Roxanne Swentzell's sculpture *Mud Woman Rolls On* consists of five human figures made of clay and plant fiber and arranged in descending size; each figure holds the smaller one in front of it. The arrangement of the figures, according to _____ represents her idea that "we all come from the Earth, generation after generation."

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

A. Swentzell

B. Swentzell,

C. Swentzell:

D. Swentzell—

Correct Answer: B

Rationale

Choice B is the best answer. The phrase "according to Swentzell" is an aside that interrupts the flow of the sentence, so it needs to be separated from the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks: two commas, two dashes, or a pair of parentheses. We already have a comma before "according," so we must add a comma after "Swentzell." .

Choice A is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. The phrase "according to Swentzell" is an aside that interrupts the flow of the sentence, so it needs to be separated from the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks: one before and one after the phrase. Choice C is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. "The arrangement of the figures, according to Swentzell" is not an independent clause, so it can't come before a colon. Choice D is incorrect. This choice creates a punctuation error. The phrase "according to Swentzell" is an aside that interrupts the flow of the sentence, so it needs to be separated from the sentence with a pair of matching punctuation marks. We already have a comma at the beginning, so we have to use another comma here to match. We can't just switch to a dash! .

Question ID: eef91a50

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Nine months before Rosa Parks made history by refusing to comply with the segregated seating policy on a Montgomery, Alabama, bus, a fifteen-year-old Montgomery girl named Claudette Colvin was arrested for the same _____ to some historians, Colvin's arrest led to Parks's action and eventually to the desegregation of Montgomery's bus system.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

A. offense. According

B. offense, according

C. offense according

D. offense and according

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. "Nine months…offense" and "according to…system" are both independent clauses. Separating them with a period and turning them into their own sentences is the only grammatically correct choice among the provided options.

Choice B is incorrect. This choice results in a comma splice error, which is a punctuation error that occurs when two independent clauses are joined by only a comma. "Nine months…offense" and "according to…system" are both independent clauses, so they need to be either joined by a semicolon, joined by a comma and a coordinating conjunction, or separated by a period. Choice C is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence, which occurs when two independent clauses are joined without punctuation. "Nine months…offense" and "according to…system" are both independent clauses, so they need to be either joined by a semicolon, joined by a comma and a coordinating conjunction, or separated by a period. Choice D is incorrect. This choice results in a run-on sentence, which occurs when two independent clauses are joined without punctuation. "Nine months…offense" and "according to…system" are independent clauses, so we would need to put a comma before the coordinating conjunction "and" to join them properly.

Question ID: 01a32c84

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

The first computerized spreadsheet, Dan Bricklin's *VisiCalc*, improved financial recordkeeping not only by providing users with an easy means of adjusting data in spreadsheets but also by automatically updating all calculations that were dependent on these _____ to VisiCalc's release, changing a paper spreadsheet often required redoing the entire sheet by hand, a process that could take days.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

A. adjustments prior

B. adjustments, prior

C. adjustments. Prior

D. adjustments and prior

Correct Answer: C

Rationale

Choice C is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between the first sentence ("The...adjustments") and the second sentence ("Prior...days"). Because the adverbial phrase beginning with "prior" indicates when changing a spreadsheet required redoing the sheet by hand, that phrase belongs with the second sentence.

Choice A is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. Two sentences are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can't be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice D is incorrect. Without a comma preceding it, the conjunction "and" can't be used in this way to join the sentences.

Question ID: 67667d72

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Medium

Question

Humans were long thought to have begun occupying the Peruvian settlement of Machu Picchu between 1440 and 1450 CE. However, a team led by anthropologist Dr. Richard Burger used accelerator mass spectrometry to uncover evidence that it was occupied _____ 1420 CE, according to Burger, humans were likely inhabiting the area.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

A. earlier. In

B. earlier, in

C. earlier, which in

D. earlier in

Correct Answer: A

Rationale

Choice A is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation use between sentences. In this choice, the period is used correctly to mark the boundary between one sentence (“However...earlier”) and another (“In...area”). The supplementary phrase “in 1420 CE” modifies “humans,” the subject of the third sentence.

Choice B is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Choice C is incorrect because it results in a comma splice. A comma can’t be used in this way to mark the boundary between sentences. Moreover, the subordinating conjunction “which” creates a confusing and illogical sentence that suggests that the supplementary phrase beginning with “in” modifies the previous information (“However...earlier”) rather than the information that follows. Choice D is incorrect because it results in a run-on sentence. The sentences (“However...earlier” and “in...area”) are fused without punctuation and/or a conjunction.